

JKBOSE 2026

CLASS 11TH

SILK ROAD

LECTURE-3

ENGLISH

HUSSAIN SIR



Topics To Covered

- 1 ... Lec. 03 (Silk Road) Detailed explanation (Word to Word)
- 2 ...
- 3 ...
- 4 ...

SILK ROAD



But I had to wait. Tsetan told me to go and drink some tea in Hor's only cafe, which, like all the other buildings in town, was constructed from badly painted concrete and had three broken windows. The good view of the lake through one of them helped to compensate for the draught.
Cold air



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I was served by a Chinese youth in military uniform who spread the grease around on my table with a filthy (dirty) rag (old, worn-out cloth) before bringing me a glass and a thermos of tea.

Half an hour later, Tsetan released me from my solitary confinement (state of being alone), and we drove past a lot more rocks and rubbish westwards out of town towards Mount Kailash.

Towards west



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My experience in Hor came as a ^{completely opposite} stark contrast (opposite) to accounts I'd read of earlier travellers' first encounters with Lake Manasarovar. Ekai Kawaguchi a Japanese monk who had arrived there in 1900, was so ^{impressed} moved by the ^{purity} sanctity (purity, sacredness) of the lake that he ^{emotional} burst into tears. A couple of years later, the ^{respected} hallowed (respected) waters had a similar effect on Sven Hedin, a Swede who wasn't ^{like to do something} prone to sentimental outbursts. → to show emotion suddenly.



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It was dark by the time we finally left again, and after 10.30 p.m., we drew up ^{stopped} outside a guest house in Darchen for what turned out to be another troubled night. Kicking ^{moving} around in the open-air rubbish dump that passed for the town of Hor had set off my cold once more, though if truth be told, it had never quite disappeared with my herbal tea. One of my nostrils was blocked again, and as I lay down to sleep, I wasn't convinced that the other would provide me with sufficient oxygen.



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My watch told me I was at 4,760 metres. It wasn't much higher than Ravu, and there I'd been gasping for oxygen several times every night. I'd grown used to accustomed to these nocturnal (at night time) disturbances by now, but they still scared me.



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Tired and hungry, I started breathing through my mouth. After a while, I switched to single-nostril power which seemed to be admitting enough oxygen but, just as I was drifting off, (sleep) I woke up abruptly. Something was wrong. My chest felt strangely heavy and I sat up, a movement that cleared my ^{nose airways} nasal passages almost instantly and ^{relief} relieved the feeling in my chest. Curious, I thought.



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I lay back down and tried again. Same result. I was on the point of disappearing into the land of nod (state of sleep) when something told me not to. It must have been those emergency electrical impulses again, but this was not the same as on previous occasions. This time, I wasn't gasping for breath; I was simply not allowed to go to sleep.



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Sitting up once more immediately made me feel better. I could breathe freely and my chest felt fine. But as soon as I lay down, my sinuses filled and my chest was odd. I tried propping (to hold up) myself upright against the wall, but now I couldn't manage to relax enough to drop off. I couldn't put my finger on the reason, but I was afraid to go to sleep. A little voice inside me was saying that if I did I might never wake up again. So I stayed awake all night.



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Tsetan took me to the Darchen medical college the following morning. The medical college at Darchen was new and looked like a religious building monastery from the outside with a very solid door that led into a large courtyard. We found the consulting room which was dark and cold and occupied by a Tibetan doctor who wore none of the paraphernalia that I'd been expecting. No white coat, he looked like any other Tibetan with a thick pullover and a woolly hat. When I explained my sleepless symptoms and my sudden aversion (dislike) to lying down, he shot me a few questions while feeling the veins in my wrist.



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“It’s a cold,” he said finally through Tsetan. “A cold and the effects of altitude. I’ll give you something for it.”

I asked him if he thought I’d recover enough to be able to do the kora. “Oh yes,” he said, “you’ll be fine.”



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I walked out of the medical college holding a brown envelope filled with fifteen screws of paper. I had a five-day course of Tibetan medicine which I started right away. I opened an after breakfast package and found it contained a brown powder that I had to take with hot water. It tasted just like cinnamon. The medicine contents of the lunchtime and bedtime packages were less obviously identifiable. Both contained small, spherical brown pellets. They looked suspiciously like sheep dung, but of course I took them. That night, after my first full day's course, I slept very soundly. Like a log, not a dead man.



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Once he saw that I was going to live Tsetan left me, to return to Lhasa. As a Buddhist, he told me, he knew that it didn't really matter if I passed away, but he thought it would be bad for business.



SILK ROAD



Darchen didn't look so ^{very bad} horrible after a good night's sleep. It was still dusty, partially derelict (ruined) and punctuated by heaps of rubble and refuse, but the sun shone brilliantly in a clear blue sky and the outlook across the plain to the south gave me a vision of the Himalayas, commanded by a huge, snow-capped mountain, Gurla Mandhata, with just a wisp (a small amount of something) of cloud suspended over its summit. (peak)



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The town had a couple of ^{Simple} rudimentary (basic or primary) general stores selling Chinese cigarettes, soap and other basic ^{necessary supplies} provisions, as well as the usual ^{Lines of religion flags} strings of prayer flags. In front of one, men gathered in the afternoon for a game of pool, the ^{old, damaged} battered table looking supremely ^{Strange} incongruous (strange) in the open air, while nearby women washed their long hair in the icy water of a narrow ^{lane} brook that ^{wise} babbled down past my guest house.



SILK ROAD



Darchen felt relaxed and ^{not rushed} unhurried but, for me, it came with a significant ^{disadvantages} drawback. There were no ^{religious travellers} pilgrims. I'd been told that at the height of the pilgrimage season, the town was ^{full of activity} bustling with visitors. Many brought their own accommodation, enlarging the settlement round its edges as they set up their tents which spilled down on to the plain. I'd timed my arrival for the beginning of the season, but it seemed I was too early.
^{before time}



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One afternoon, I sat pondering my options over a glass of tea in Darchen's only cafe. After a little Careful thinking consideration, I concluded they were severely limited. Clearly, I hadn't made much progress with my self-help programme on positive thinking.



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In my defence, it hadn't been easy with all my sleeping difficulties, but however I looked at it, I could only wait. The pilgrimage ^{route} trail was well-trodden (frequented many by many travellers). I didn't ^{like} fancy doing ^{kora} it alone. The kora was seasonal because parts of the route were ^{likely to} liable to blockage by snow. I had no idea whether or not the snow had cleared, but I wasn't encouraged by the chunks of dirty ice that still clung to the banks of Darchen's brook. Since Tsetan had left, I hadn't come across anyone in Darchen with enough English to answer even this most basic question.



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Until, that is, I met Norbu. The cafe was small, dark and like a cave cavernous, with a long metal stove that ran down the middle. The walls and ceiling were wreathed (twisted) in sheets of multi-coloured plastic, of the striped variety, broad blue, red and white that is made into stout, strong large, big voluminous shopping bags sold all over China, and in many other countries of Asia as well as Europe. As such, plastic must rate as one of China's most successful exports along the Silk Road today.

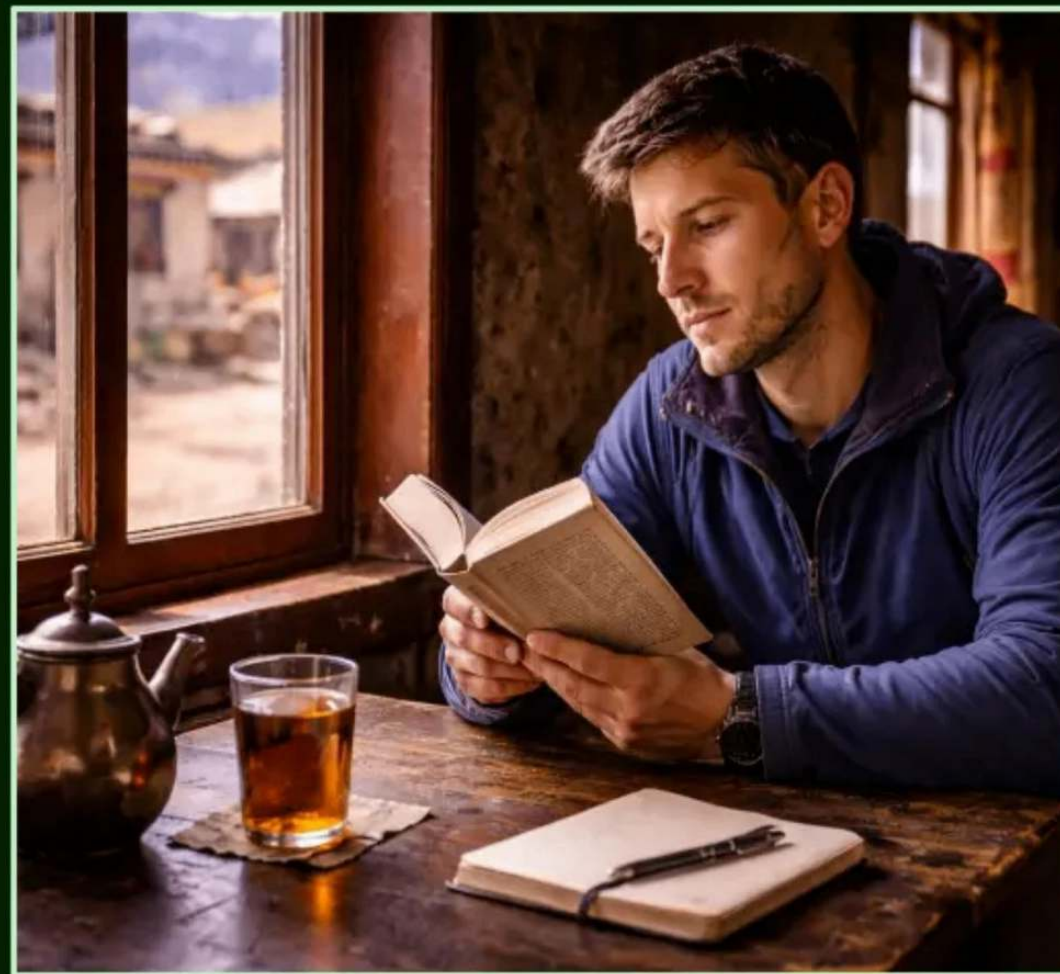


SILK ROAD



The cafe had a single window beside which I'd taken up position so that I could see the pages of my notebook. I'd also brought a novel with me to help pass the time.

Norbu saw my book when he came in and asked with a gesture if he could sit opposite me at my rickety ^{unstable} (unstable) table. "You English?" he enquired, after he'd ordered tea. I told him I was, and we struck up ^{started} a conversation.



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I didn't think he was from those parts because he was wearing a light jacket windcheater and metal-rimmed spectacles of a Western style. He was Tibetan, he told me, but worked in Beijing at the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences, in the Institute of Literature of different cultures Ethnic Literature. I assumed thought he was on some sort of fieldwork.



SILK ROAD



“Yes and no,” he said. “I have come to do the kora.”
My ^{± got very happy} heart jumped. Norbu had been writing academic papers about the Kailash kora and its importance in various works of Buddhist literature for many years, he told me, but he had never actually done it himself.



SILK ROAD



When the time came for me to tell him what brought me to Darchen, his eyes lit up. “We could be a team,” he said excitedly. “Two academics who have escaped from the library.” Perhaps my positive-thinking strategy was working after all.



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My ^{starting} initial relief at meeting Norbu, who was also staying in the guest house, was tempered by the realisation that he was almost as ill-equipped as I was for the pilgrimage. He kept telling me how fat he was and how hard it was going to be. "Very high up," he kept reminding me, "so tiresome to walk." He wasn't really a practising Buddhist, it ^{became know} transpired, but he had ^{excitement, interest} enthusiasm, and he was, of course, Tibetan.



SILK ROAD



Although I'd originally ^{imagined} envisaged (predicted) making the ^{difficult journey} trek in the company of devout believers, on reflection, I decided that perhaps Norbu would turn out to be the ideal companion. He suggested we hire some yaks to carry our luggage, which I interpreted as a good sign, and he had no intention of prostrating (lying down) himself all round the mountain. "Not possible," he cried, collapsing across the table in hysterical laughter. It wasn't his style, and anyway, his tummy was too big.



A decorative graphic featuring five red hearts arranged in a horizontal row, with five yellow stars positioned directly below each heart.

Thank
You